CA/Browser Forum Tracker

Part 1 - Server Certificate Working Group

Last updated: 2026-10-25

About This Report

This is an experimental, AI-driven research project from SRL. SRL is independent, with no outside funding and no sponsors. This tracker is a summarized pull of the public record, kept as a coherent, concise news update. It draws on the CA/Browser Forum's own ballots, mailing lists and published documents, and on the public sources of the browser root programs. An AI model reads those sources and writes the summary, and every statement links to the source it came from. Where two sources disagree, both are reported. AI makes mistakes, so check the linked source before relying on any statement. The tracker is updated each week that the public record shows a change.

The Server Certificate Working Group writes the rules for the certificates that secure the public web. It is the busiest of the Forum's groups. Its Baseline Requirements reached version 2.3.1 on 4 October 2026, the second new version since the start of September [1].

This part covers three strands of its work. Section 1 follows the ballots and the document versions they produce, where one ballot is now in its vote. Section 2 covers domain control validation, where the next hard deadline falls in December. Section 3 covers certificate profiles and cryptography, including the shrinking validity schedule, the closed post-quantum draft, and a new draft on key quality written in response to a key compromise.

One distinction governs everything below. A ballot that passes its vote is not yet a requirement. It enters a 30-day intellectual property review, and only after that does the text publish into a numbered version. A separate effective date decides when certificate authorities must comply. This part states the stage of every ballot, because confusing those states produces confident statements about rules that bind no one yet.

1. Ballots and Document Versions

The Baseline Requirements move by ballot. Each ballot that changes the text produces a numbered version, and the Forum's revision table is the authoritative record of what is in force.

Recent Developments

Ballot SC105 moved to a vote on 21 October. It removes the High Risk Certificate Request language from both the Baseline Requirements and the Extended Validation Guidelines, and is written against version 2.3.1 [2]. Its discussion period ran from 14 October with no replies, and voting runs from 21 October at 16:00 UTC to 28 October at 16:00 UTC [2]. The chair's agenda update of 22 October asked members to vote [3].

By 22 October four votes in favour were readable, from TWCA, Kamu SM, DigiCert and OISTE, with none against [2]. The concept the ballot removes came from the Validation Subcommittee, which judged it subjective and outdated in July [4].

The group published the minutes of its September face-to-face meeting on 23 October [5]. The chair's report lists four ballots under consideration, a proposal to issue formal revisions of the Baseline Requirements only once or twice a year, and 74 open issues [5]. The minutes also carry the first full record of Chrome's proposal to modernise certificate profiles, which Section 3 describes [5].

A new draft ballot answers the week's key compromise. On 22 October Aaron Gable of Let's Encrypt opened a draft that reorganises the key quality checks and adds a test for ECDSA private scalars smaller than 256, effective 15 January 2027 [6]. It names "the recent compromise of eight ECDSA Subordinate CA private keys" as its motive and asks the list for endorsers [6]. Part 4 covers that compromise. A second unnumbered draft, from 20 October, clarifies the allowances for the country name field [7].

Two ballots published into the Baseline Requirements in the past eight weeks. Version 2.3.0 took effect on 7 September 2026, carrying Ballot SC100 on DNSSEC clarification and consolidation [8]. Version 2.3.1 followed on 4 October and carries Ballot SC104, which turns the Authority Information Access extension in subscriber certificates from a requirement into a recommendation [1] [9]. SC104 passed on 3 September with 21 issuer votes and five consumer votes, and its review ended with no exclusion notices [9] [10]. The extended validation rules moved earlier: Ballot SC102 was published as version 2.0.4 of the Extended Validation Guidelines, effective 13 August [11].

A proposal outside any ballot reached the list on 16 October. It would require an authority to revoke a certificate on an actionable notice that the subscriber appears on a terrorism, sanctions or war crimes list [12]. The replies were sceptical, asking who would maintain such a list and arguing that the Baseline Requirements are the wrong home for it [12]. The thread grew to six messages and has been quiet since 18 October [12]. It leans on the High Risk language that SC105 would delete, so the two discussions touch [12] [2].

A public objection to the validity schedule reached the group on 22 October. An IT director at an electrical contractor wrote that the reductions under Ballot SC-081v3 are unsustainable, and the chair forwarded the message for the group's consideration [13]. A reply noted that the 47-day maximum does not apply until 15 March 2029 and asked for an assessment of operational impact [13].

Current State

The ballot with the widest reach is stuck in discussion. SC-107, proposed by Sectigo and endorsed by Google and DigiCert, would tighten certificate problem reports and define what revocation means [14]. A report would need at least a serial number or hash, plus a described violation or a revocation reason, and the authority would have 24 hours to judge it actionable [14].

The same ballot defines a certificate as revoked once its serial number appears in a revocation list or draws a revoked status response, from 15 February 2027 [14]. Its redline adds a 120-hour window to check the rest of an authority's certificates for the same fault [15]. Its discussion period was due to end on 1 October [14].

By 15 October the thread held 22 messages and no vote had been called [14]. The newest concerned limiting that 120-hour check to certificates from authorities whose keys the certificate owner controls [14]. Nothing has been posted since, and a search on 25 October still found no voting thread [16]. The Forum's ballots page now lists the ballot under its discussion period, which it did not on 18 October [17].

Two other server ballots sit short of a vote. SC103, which would require Extended Key Usage extensions on cross-certified subordinate authorities, remains in its discussion period [17]. The face-to-face minutes record it as "pending Aaron Gable's availability", and its thread has had no post since June [5]. SC-106, the post-quantum ballot covered in Section 3, has lost its draft text and is being taken over by a new proposer [18].

A draft omnibus ballot would reshape the extended validation rules. It moves the EV certificate profile from the Extended Validation Guidelines into the Baseline Requirements and turns the guidelines into a validation methods document [19]. It has no ballot number, and its text was revised on 20 October to clarify wording [19]. Version 2.0.4 remains the current Extended Validation Guidelines [11].

The group's 22 October call deferred the topics carried over from the face-to-face meeting, with one Chrome representative absent and the agenda saying the group hopes to resume those discussions shortly [18]. It added a new item on ECDSA key size requirements, and the minutes of the 8 October call had still not been distributed [18]. The next call is on 4 November [18].

Unresolved Conflicts

The Forum's own records disagree about version 2.3.1. The requirements page lists it as current and dated 4 October [1]. The Forum's GitHub repository has no release or tag for it, and its newest tag is still 2.3.0 [20]. The requirements page is the authoritative record, and a release tag would close the gap.

2. Domain Control Validation

Domain control validation is how a certificate authority satisfies itself that the applicant controls the name being certified. The rules are converging on one goal, which is to make control of a single network path insufficient to obtain a certificate.

Recent Developments

No validation method ballot has entered any stage since September [17]. The work instead moved through drafts, guidance and one large issuer's own schedule.

A revised ACME persistent DNS method was posted to the Validation Subcommittee on 26 September [21]. Its second draft replaces the account address in the DNS record with a hash over the account's public key and metadata, as a defence against malicious proxy servers [21]. Four open issues on how that method fits Section 3.2.2.4.22 may feed a coming ballot, and they have not moved since July [21] [22].

The subcommittee is also preparing guidance on artificial intelligence in validation. A post to the subcommittee on 1 October proposed a definition separating AI from the deterministic automation already used in validation [23]. The post suggested informative guidance, perhaps as

an appendix to the Baseline Requirements, with minimal normative rules such as disclosure in practice statements [23].

Its 15 October agenda added three discussions, on country code clarification, on validating reliable data sources, and on validation and revocation issues tied to sanctions enforcement [24]. The country code item produced the draft of 20 October noted in Section 1 [7]. No minutes have been posted since the July meeting, and the subcommittee's list has had no post since 13 October [25].

Let's Encrypt is moving ahead of the rules on network perspectives. It announced two more remote perspectives, bringing its total to six, ahead of the Forum's requirement of five from 15 December [26]. They reach its staging environment on 27 October and production on 10 November [26].

Current State

Multi-Perspective Issuance Corroboration has been mandatory since 15 September 2025 under Ballot SC-067 [27]. It requires that domain validation and CAA checks be confirmed from network vantage points that differ by geography and topology [27]. The purpose is to defeat attacks on a single network path, such as DNS manipulation and route hijacking [27].

The requirement is arriving in steps. Version 2.3.1 requires four remote perspectives now and five from 15 December 2026 [1]. Two more validation dates follow. From 15 November 2026, a reverse address lookup must use the exact lookup name, and from 15 March 2027, processing of the CAA account and validation method parameters becomes mandatory [1].

DNSSEC rules are now consolidated. SC100 gathered rules scattered through the document into a new Section 4.2.2.2 and published in version 2.3.0 [28] [8]. It settles that DNSSEC validation may run on remote perspectives but is required only on the primary one [28].

The set of permitted methods keeps contracting. Ballot SC090, published as version 2.2.2 in November 2025, gradually sunsets the email-based and phone-based methods [29]. Reuse periods are contracting alongside validity. Validation data may be reused for 200 days on certificates issued until 15 March 2027, then 100 days until March 2029 [1].

3. Certificate Profiles and Cryptography

This section holds the change with the widest operational reach, the staged reduction of certificate lifetimes. It also holds the question the industry is waiting on, which is when post-quantum keys become permissible, and the first proposed rule written in response to a weak-key compromise.

Recent Developments

A key compromise has reached the rulebook. On 17 October eight eMudhra intermediate authorities were found to have ECDSA private keys small enough to recover, and Part 4 carries that story [30]. Within five days the draft described in Section 1 proposed that authorities reject ECDSA private scalars smaller than 256 from 15 January 2027 [6]. It would also reorganise the existing key quality checks into one place [6]. It is a draft without a number, and the group has put ECDSA key size requirements on its agenda [18].

The post-quantum ballot lost its text. On 21 October the author of SC-106 closed the pull request that carried the draft, unmerged, with the words “I am closing this PR” [31]. The closing note records where the browsers stand [31].

Chrome, Mozilla and Cloudflare favour dropping the restriction that a post-quantum authority may sign only post-quantum certificates [31]. Chrome keeps the path where a classical authority signs a post-quantum certificate, and the question of a cross-signed ML-DSA root is open [31]. The note says the profile will be proposed in a future working group for consumers other than browsers [31].

The face-to-face minutes published on 23 October give the first full record of Chrome’s profile proposal [5]. It would make disclosed certificate profiles the only permitted ones and turn pre-issuance linting from a recommendation into a requirement [5]. It would also raise the self-audit sample in Section 8.7 from three percent to every certificate, and move toward dedicated hierarchies on a timeline yet to be set [5].

The first phase of the SHA-1 sunset took effect on 15 September 2026 [32]. Authorities may no longer sign new revocation lists with SHA-1, and must revoke any unexpired subordinate certificate carrying a SHA-1 signature [32]. Within days, four authorities had incident reports open for missing that deadline, as Part 4 records [33] [34].

Let’s Encrypt chose to shorten certificates faster than the schedule requires. It announced on 7 October that its default lifetime falls from 90 days to 64 days on 10 February 2027 [35]. Reuse of a domain authorization falls from 30 days to 10 days at the same time, and a second step in 2028 brings a 45-day default [35]. Its staging environment switched to 64-day certificates on 14 October [35].

Current State

Ballot SC081v3 sets the Forum’s own schedule, a staged reduction of validity and data reuse periods rather than a single cutover [36]. Its first step is in force. Certificates issued from 15 March 2026 may last at most 200 days [36].

Two further steps are scheduled and not yet binding. Maximum validity falls to 100 days on 15 March 2027 and to 47 days on 15 March 2029 [36]. Version 2.3.1 carries that schedule unchanged, and the objection noted in Section 1 is the first public challenge to it since adoption [1] [13].

Post-quantum signatures are still not permitted in publicly trusted TLS certificates. Ballot SC-106 would permit ML-DSA keys and signatures in all three parameter sets, in server certificates, issuing authorities, revocation lists and status responses [31]. Its text said that passing it would not require any root store to trust ML-DSA [31]. The draft required pure post-quantum chains, so an ML-DSA key had to be certified by an ML-DSA signature, and Mozilla and Chrome representatives objected to that restriction in August [37].

The ballot now has a successor without a text. The group’s 22 October agenda still lists SC-106 as a draft, with Amazon Trust Services taking over from Google Trust Services and an update expected [18]. The closed pull request is the only redline that ever existed, and no discussion thread has been opened [31] [38]. SC-106 does not appear on the group’s ballots page [17].

The group recorded in May that post-quantum certificates have two blocking dependencies, and only one belongs to the Forum [39]. The Baseline Requirements must permit ML-DSA, and the IETF must finish the encoding standards for post-quantum algorithms in certificates [39]. Part 6 follows the IETF side, where the composite signature draft is one step from publication.

Unresolved Conflicts

The status of SC-106 is unclear. Its pull request is closed and its author has stepped back, which in the repository looks like withdrawal [31]. The group's agenda lists it as a live draft with a new proposer [18]. The minutes of the 22 October call, when posted, or a new redline from Amazon Trust Services, would settle which reading is right.

The Forum's working groups are not moving together on post-quantum algorithms. The server group has no draft text and no ballot in any formal stage [17] [31]. The S/MIME group published post-quantum algorithms in 2025 and has its composite draft on its agenda, as Part 3 records. The two groups govern different certificate profiles and need not move in step. A discussion period for a new SC-106 text would mark the server group's first formal step.

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